

First Read

Tencent Holdings

2Q26 preview; core resilience to fund AI investments

2Q26 preview

We expect 2Q **revenue** to grow +9% YoY, with **adj. NP** +4% to Rmb66bn. By segment: **1) Games:** i) Domestic: We expect growth to pick up to +10% for 2Q (1Q's +6%), on the back of the resilient grossings of evergreen titles (i.e. Honor of Kings, PeaceKeeper Elite and Delta Force), as well as the incremental contribution of the newly launched Roco Kingdom. ii) International: We forecast growth to moderate to +8% (1Q's +13%), given tougher comp on Supercell and Kuro consolidation (in Dec-24). **2) Ad:** anticipated at +18% YoY (1Q +20%), moderating off a higher base but continued supported by ad-tech upgrades, Video Accounts (increasing traffic and ad load), and higher eCPM ad formats (i.e. rewarded ads, close-looped ads). **3) FinTech (FBS):** estimated to slightly moderate to +8% (1Q's +9%), amid soft payment growth amid weak macro. Cloud growth should have accelerated on improving chip availability, and should set to further pick up into 2H. **4) Margin:** we model GP +11% YoY (GPM 57.9%) on better business mix towards high margin business, and adj. OP +7% YoY to Rmb74bn as AI opex and depreciation ramp.

Key focuses into result

1) AI strategy and capex: The market would focus on Tencent's model and AI product rollout, which we have observed +ve progress, including HY3.0 model (with improving user feedback), WorkBuddy (a leading AI productivity software with 8m monthly visits in Mar, which should have continued to ramp; Tencent expanded HY capacity following emerging usage on [8 Jul](#)), and Weixin AI agent trial since early June. Accordingly, we forecast Tencent's capex to increase to Rmb170bn (1Q's Rmb32bn; 2025 Rmb87bn), with an increase in 2H as domestic chip supply eases.

2) Online games outlook: While domestic grossing should have remained resilient at c10% YoY based on our checks, 2H growth could face pressure from tougher comparison base (cons +11-12% for 2H) with no major title launch. That said, AI-enabled and more frequent content creation and update with a lower iOS commission (started in Mar) could provide potential margin upside.

3) Ad outlook: Growth sustainability is the key to monitor amid more challenging base into 2H. That said, we see levers from Video Accounts, rising share of higher eCPM ad formats, ad tech upgrade (an estimated 10% uplift in CTR and eCPM), and automated media buying AIM+ (UBSe 30% penetration) to monetize under-utilized inventory.

Valuation and what to do with the stock

Investors' feedback on Tencent has been mixed. **From a fundamental perspective,** investors generally value **1)** Tencent mgmt's strong execution track record, solid FCF

Equities

China
Internet Services

12-month rating **Buy**

12m price target **HK\$780.00**

Price (09 Jul 2026) **HK\$469.60**

RIC: 0700.HK BBG: 700 HK

Trading data and key metrics

52-wk range	HK\$677.50-411.80
Market cap.	HK\$4,266b/US\$544b
Shares o/s	9,085m (ORD)
Free float	66%
Avg. daily volume ('000)	31,468
Avg. daily value (m)	HK\$14,434
Common s/h equity (12/26E)	Rmb1336b
P/BV (12/26E)	2.7x
Net debt to EBITDA (12/26E)	NM

EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)

	From	To	% ch	Cons.
12/26E	30.24	29.97	-1	30.31
12/27E	33.77	33.46	-1	33.51
12/28E	37.24	36.91	-1	37.59

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Highlights (Rmbm)	12/23	12/24	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E	12/30E
Revenues	609,015	660,257	751,766	817,656	897,856	973,698	1,054,954	1,144,012
EBIT (UBS)	205,694	253,815	297,565	315,888	354,677	390,538	428,211	469,592
Net earnings (UBS)	157,688	222,703	259,626	274,246	306,215	337,800	371,081	407,619
EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)	16.41	23.67	28.09	29.97	33.46	36.91	40.55	44.54
DPS (net) (Rmb)	3.46	4.57	5.39	5.78	6.46	7.12	7.83	8.60
Net (debt) / cash	13,503	(9,785)	(2,914)	85,965	231,070	442,406	678,793	947,734
Profitability/valuation	12/23	12/24	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E	12/30E
EBIT (UBS) margin %	33.8	38.4	39.6	38.6	39.5	40.1	40.6	41.0
ROIC (EBIT) %	34.3	37.2	35.8	33.8	35.5	38.0	41.3	45.0
EV/EBITDA (UBS core) x	10.1	9.3	12.0	8.5	7.6	7.0	6.4	5.8
P/E (UBS, diluted) x	18.5	14.0	17.7	13.7	12.2	11.0	10.0	9.1
Equity FCF (UBS) yield %	6.2	5.5	4.1	4.9	6.5	8.5	9.3	10.3
Dividend yield (net) %	1.1	1.4	1.1	1.4	1.6	1.7	1.9	2.1

Source: Company accounts, LSEG Eikon, UBS estimates. Metrics marked as (UBS) have had analyst adjustments applied. Valuations: based on an average share price that year, (E): based on a share price of HK\$ 469.60 on 09-Jul-2026

generation of its core businesses, particularly online games, which can fund AI investment, and **2)** its undemanding valuation at 13x 2026E P/E, providing downside support with potential value to be unlocked from its cRmb1trn investment portfolio. That said, **from a share price catalyst perspective**, the stock may lack a near-term re-rating driver, as **1)** Tencent still faces EPS downgrade risk as it significantly increases AI spending in 2026E. **2)** Its LLM strategy is more oriented toward practical applications than rankings, and AI contribution is less measurable because it is integrated across multiple product lines, unlike peers that separately disclose MaaS ARR, GPU sales, or cloud metrics, which allows investors to value their AI assets more directly. **As a result, investors may only benchmark Tencent's headline P/E against its EPS growth**, which is expected to be single digit in 2026E/27E, rather than applying a SOTP framework that could imply greater upside given the re-rating in AI assets (e.g. GPU and LLM).

Overall, we reiterate our Buy rating on Tencent. We believe the gradual shift in the AI industry from LLM competition toward products and monetization should align well with Tencent's strengths. The company has **1)** capital base, supported by a strong balance sheet and FCF, **2)** proprietary user data, a large user base with clear use cases, as demonstrated by the recent success of WorkBuddy, and **3)** one of the leading LLMs, HY3.0. These capabilities should enable Tencent to perform well and reinforce Weixin's leadership as a traffic entry point and expand footprint into the To-B applications. **For 2H26, the market's focus is likely to be** feedback on the HY4 release and continued scaling of AI products, including WorkBuddy and the Weixin agent. Overall, as AI investment is likely to continue over multiple years, we believe Tencent's resilient core businesses in games and advertising, with UBSe ex-AI investment OP expected to grow 15% in 2026E, together with its under-monetized ecosystems, provide a strong foundation.

Figure 1: 2Q26 preview summary

(Rmb m)	2Q25	1Q26	2Q26E	QoQ	YoY	Cons	+/-
a. VAS	91,368	96,110	97,737	1.7%	7.0%	98,481	-0.8%
Domestic games	40,368	45,410	44,618	-1.7%	10.5%	44,997	-0.8%
International games	18,800	18,800	20,304	8.0%	8.0%	20,719	-2.0%
Core social network	32,200	31,900	32,815	2.9%	1.9%	32,732	0.3%
b. Marketing services	35,762	38,171	42,106	10.3%	17.7%	42,329	-0.5%
c. Fintech & business services	55,536	59,885	59,754	-0.2%	7.6%	60,368	-1.0%
d. Others	1,838	2,292	2,206	-3.8%	20.0%	2,069	6.6%
Total revenue	184,504	196,458	201,803	2.7%	9.4%	203,339	-0.8%
YoY % chg	14.5%	9.1%	9.4%			10.2%	-0.8%
Gross profit	105,013	111,265	116,929	5.1%	11.3%	116,077	0.7%
YoY % chg	22.3%	10.7%	11.3%			10.6%	0.7%
GPM %	56.9%	56.6%	57.9%	1.3pcts	1.0pcts	57.1%	0.9pcts
Value added services	60.4%	62.6%	63.5%	0.9pcts	3.1pcts	61.5%	2.0pcts
Marketing services	57.6%	55.0%	57.0%	2.0pcts	-0.6pcts	57.9%	-0.9pcts
Fintech and business services	52.1%	52.1%	53.5%	1.4pcts	1.4pcts	51.5%	2.0pcts
Others	13.8%	-44.9%	-50.0%	-5.1pcts	-63.8pcts	-3.9%	-46.1pcts
Selling and marketing	(9,410)	(11,343)	(14,530)	28.1%	54.4%	(12,221)	18.9%
General and administrative	(31,921)	(33,800)	(36,728)	8.7%	15.1%	(37,810)	-2.9%
Non-GAAP operating profit	69,248	75,627	74,188	-1.9%	7.1%	75,711	-2.0%
Adj. OPM %	37.5%	38.5%	36.8%	-1.7pcts	-0.8pcts	37.2%	-0.5pcts
YoY % chg	18.5%	9.1%	7.1%			9.3%	-23.6%
Share of gains from associates and JVs	4,473	3,620	2,774	-23.4%	-38.0%	4,359	-36.4%
Income tax expense	(11,351)	(14,577)	(12,676)	-13.0%	11.7%	(13,803)	-8.2%
Non-GAAP net profit	63,052	67,905	65,844	-3.0%	4.4%	68,940	-4.5%
YoY % chg	10.0%	10.7%	4.4%			9.3%	-4.9%
Adj. NPM %	34.2%	34.6%	32.6%	-1.9pcts	-1.5pcts	33.9%	-1.3pcts

Source: Visible Alpha, Company data, UBS estimates

Forecast returns

Forecast price appreciation	66.1%
Forecast dividend yield	1.4%
Forecast stock return	67.5%
Market return assumption	11.1%
Forecast excess return	56.5%

Company Description

Tencent has the largest online community in China. It was founded with the launch of instant messaging platform QQ but has since grown into a diversified internet company with core focuses on gaming, social media and networking (Weixin/WeChat), fintech (WeChat Pay), cloud computing and digital content. The company also holds a substantial investment portfolio of public and private companies.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our price target is based on sum of the parts.

We believe the key risks for Tencent include: 1) an evolving and intensifying competitive landscape; 2) new business execution; 3) integration of invested companies and businesses; 4) rising costs of traffic acquisition, content and brand promotions; 5) IT system upkeep; 6) expansion into international markets; 7) infringement of intellectual property rights; 8) departures of key management; and 9) regulatory risks.

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Tencent Holdings

Question	Response
1. Is the industry structure facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting worse, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
2. Is the regulatory/government environment facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting tougher, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
3. Over the last 3-6 months in broad terms have things been improving/no change/getting worse for this stock? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting a lot worse, 3 = not much change, 5 = getting a lot better, N/A = no view)	4
4. Relative to the current CONSENSUS EPS forecast, is the next company EPS update likely to lead to: (1 = negative surprise vs consensus, 3 = in-line with consensus, 5 = positive surprise vs consensus expectations, N/A = no view)	3
5. What's driving the difference?	
6. Relative to YOUR current earnings forecast, is there relatively greater risk at the next earnings result of: (1 = downside skew risk to earnings, 3 = equal upside or downside risk to earnings, 5 = upside skew risk to earnings, N/A = no view)	3
7. What's driving the difference?	
8. Is there an upcoming catalyst for the company over the next three months?	
9. Is there an actual or approximate date for the catalyst?	
10. Is the catalyst date an actual or approximate date?	
11. What is the catalyst?	

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Buy	FSR is > 6% above the MRA.	55%	24%
Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	40%	21%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 30 June 2026.

1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.

2:Percentage of companies within the 12-month rating category for which investment banking (IB) services were provided within the past 12 months.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Tencent Holdings ^{16,28}	0700.HK	Buy	HK\$469.60	09 Jul 2026

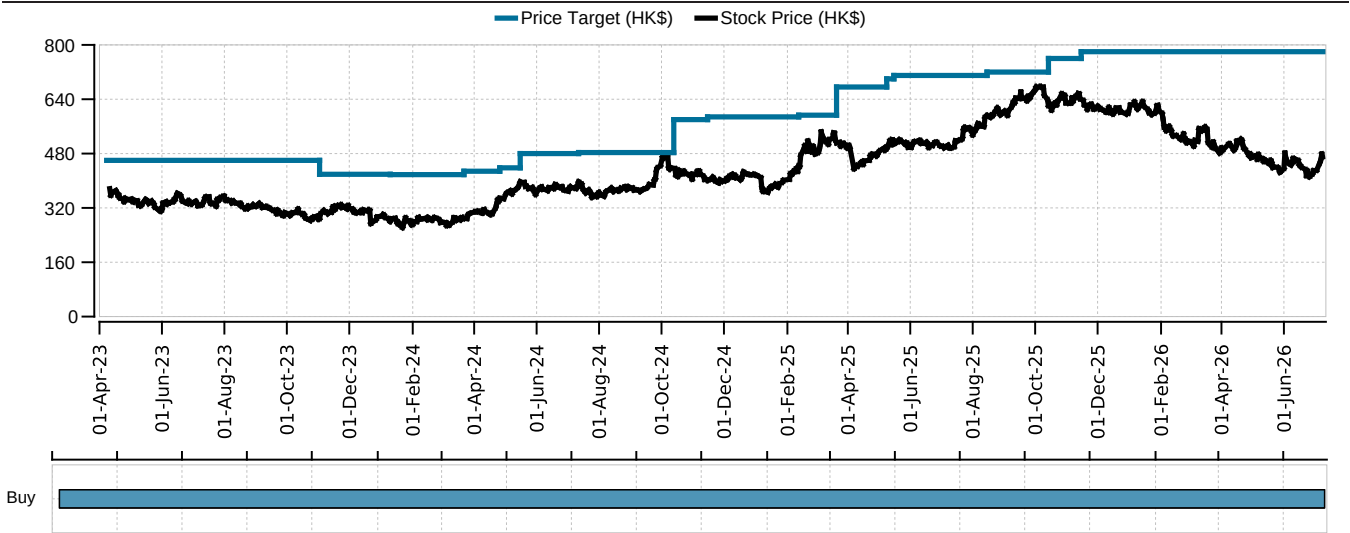
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Tencent Holdings (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-04-07	NaN	460.00	Buy
2023-11-01	287.00	419.00	Buy
2024-01-09	283.60	418.00	Buy
2024-03-21	291.20	428.00	Buy
2024-04-25	339.40	438.00	Buy
2024-05-15	381.80	480.00	Buy
2024-07-11	384.80	483.00	Buy
2024-10-12	438.80	580.00	Buy
2024-11-14	403.40	588.00	Buy
2025-02-11	427.40	593.00	Buy
2025-03-20	519.50	676.00	Buy
2025-05-08	498.00	700.00	Buy
2025-05-15	520.00	710.00	Buy
2025-08-14	590.00	720.00	Buy
2025-10-13	639.00	760.00	Buy
2025-11-14	641.00	780.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 09-Jul-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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